

Iredell County Fire Marshal's Office
North Carolina Fire Code
TENT PERMIT REQUIREMENTS OVERVIEW
Chapter 31

(This memo is not all inclusive; contact the Fire Marshal's Office for any questions)

3103.2 Approval Required (Permit Required)

Tents having an area of more than **800 sq. ft. (400 sq. ft. for Membrane Structures)** shall not be erected, operated, or maintained for any purpose without first obtaining a permit and approval from the fire code official.

Exceptions:

1. Tents are used exclusively for recreational camping purposes.
2. Tents **open on all sides** which comply with all the following:
 - 2.1 Individual tents having a maximum size of **1800 sq. ft.**
 - 2.2 The aggregate area of **multiple tents placed side by side** without a fire break clearance of 12 feet, but not exceeding **1800 sq. ft.** total.
 - 2.3 A minimum, of 12 feet to all structures and other tents (**permitted tents only**)

3103.5 Use Period

Temporary tents and membrane structure permits shall not be constructed for a period to exceed **180 days** within a twelve-month period on a single premise.

3103.6 Construction Document

A detailed site and floor plan for tents or membrane structures with an **occupancy load exceeding 50 persons** or more with each application shall be provided indicating exit ways, isles, seating arrangements, location and type of heating and electrical services.

3103.8.1 Access

A fire department access road shall be provided in accordance with Section 503.

3103.8.2 Location

Tents or membrane structures shall not be located within **20 feet** of lot lines, buildings, other tents, canopies or membrane structures, parked vehicles or internal combustion engines. For determining required distances, support ropes and guy wires shall be considered as part of the temporary membrane structure or tent.

Exception: 2.1

Eliminates the 20-foot separation from buildings as well, when the tent has an aggregate floor area not exceeding 10,000 sq. ft. So, unless the tent is extremely large there are no separation requirements in the code for buildings or structures. **The 20-foot separation from lot lines, parked vehicles and internal combustion engines is still in effect.**

3103.8.3 Location and Distance from Structures That Exceed 15,000 sq. ft.

Membrane structures or tents that exceed **15,000 sq. ft.** or more shall not be located less than **50 ft.** from any tent or structure.

3103.9 Fire Breaks

A **12-foot fire break** free of obstructions shall be maintained on all sides of all membrane structures and tents unless approved by the fire code official.

3103.9 Anchorage Required

Tents and membrane structures shall be **anchored** to withstand the element of weather and prevention against collapse.

3103.12.6 Exits Signs

Exits shall be clearly marked when the exit serves over **50 persons**.

2403.12.6.1.1&2 Exit Light Illumination

Exit signs shall be **illuminated** with occupancy loads above 50 persons.

3103.12.7 Means Of Egress Illumination (50 persons or more)

Means of egress shall be **illuminated** with light having an intensity of not less than 1 foot-candle at the floor.

3104.2 Flame Propagation Performance Treatment

All tents and membrane structures shall be treated with a **flame retardant**.

3104.3 Labels

Membrane structures and tents must have a **permanently affixed label** of size and fabric, or material treated.

3104.4 Certification (proof of fire-retardant treatment)

An affidavit or affirmation **shall be submitted** to the fire code official to verify the date and type of fire-retardant solution used for treatment.

3104.5 Combustible Materials

Hay, straw, shavings, or similar combustible materials shall not be located within any tent, or membrane structure containing an assembly occupancy, except when the materials are necessary for the daily feeding and care of animals. Sawdust and shavings utilized for a

Public performance or exhibit shall not be prohibited provided that the sawdust and shavings are kept damp. **Combustible materials shall not be permitted under stands or seats at any time.**

3104.6 Smoking

Smoking shall not be permitted in tents or membrane structures. Approved **"No Smoking"** signs shall be conspicuously posted.

3104.7 Open or Exposed Flame

Open flame or other devices emitting flame, fire or heat or any flammable or combustible liquids, gas, charcoal or other cooking device or any other unapproved devices shall not be permitted inside or located within **20 feet** of the tent or membrane structures while open to the public unless approved by the fire code official.

3104.8 Fireworks

No fireworks allowed within 100 feet of a tent or membrane structure. **(Note: Airborne fireworks display requires the approval of the fire code official and the County Board of Commissioners)**

3104.12 Portable Fire Extinguishers

Fire extinguishers shall be provided as required by Section 906. Generally, one 5 lb. ABC for each 3,000 square feet with a maximum travel distance of 75 feet. Extinguishers shall be maintained and serviced annually (as denoted by a currently dated tag attached to the extinguisher).

3104.15.3 Location

Cooking and heating equipment shall not be located within **10 feet of exits** or combustible materials.

3104.15.6 Outdoor Cooking

Outdoor cooking that produces **sparks or grease-laden vapors** shall not be performed within **20 feet** of a tent or membrane structure.

3104.20 Standby Personnel

When in the opinion of the fire code official, the use of standby personnel may be required to protect the public.

3104.20.2 Crowd Managers

There shall be trained crowd manager/supervisors at a ratio of one crowd manager/supervisor for every 250 occupants, as approved.

3104.21 Combustible Vegetation

The areas within and adjacent to the tent or air-supported structure shall be maintained clear of all combustible materials or vegetation that could create a fire hazard within 30 feet from the structure.

3104.22 Combustible Waste Material

Combustible trash shall be stored in approved containers and removed at least once a day from the structure during the period the structure is occupied by the public.